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Perimeters: From Cooperation to Conflict

Perceptions matter, but India and China are also not friends because since 1949 they have not been able to agree on their perimeters – on the definition of their boundaries, on the status of Tibet which sits between the heartlands of the two societies, and on the nature of their military presence and actions in forward areas. In October 1962 when they went to war, the Indian and Chinese leaderships were deeply suspicious of each other on all three issues despite attempts to cooperate. The war seemed to bring to a climax their antagonism. This might have led to a resolution of their differences. Or it could have resulted in an alienation so complete that any form of normal intercourse would have become impossible. In fact, after some years, Delhi and Beijing returned to a process of cooperation on the border, Tibet, and military relations. By the summer of 2020, when the two armies fought on the Galwan heights, a second period of cooperation closed, once again in a violent encounter and the threat of war, eerily reminiscent of 1962.

Background

To understand the quarrel between India and China over their perimeters, a little background is vital on the border, Tibet, and military relations in the Himalaya. The India–China border stretches from Aksai Chin in the west, through a so-called middle sector, to Arunachal Pradesh in the east. The dispute in the western sector is over Aksai Chin, bordering Ladakh. In the middle sector, the contestation is over relatively small strips of territory